

Figurative Language - Study Guide

Interpret nonliteral language and explain what it contributes to meaning, mood, or emphasis.

Learning goal

Understand what a comparison, image, idiom, or personification means in context and explain its effect instead of merely naming the device.

What this skill really means

Figurative language says more than the literal words. It can compress an idea, create an image, show intensity, or shape how a reader feels about a moment.

On an RLA-style question, knowing "this is a metaphor" is often not enough. You usually need to explain what the metaphor means or why the writer uses it.

Weak response	Stronger response	Why stronger
It is a metaphor.	The metaphor presents the hallway as crowded and difficult to move through.	It interprets the meaning.
It adds imagery.	The image makes the cold seem sharp and uncomfortable.	It explains the effect.
It is personification.	Giving the storm a voice makes it seem threatening and active.	It connects device to reader effect.

How exam-style questions ask it

- What does the comparison ___ mean in the passage?
- What is the effect of the phrase ___?
- Why does the author describe ___ as ___?

A reliable method

1. Decide what is literally happening first.
2. Identify what two ideas or images are being connected.
3. Ask which quality is transferred from the image to the real subject.
4. Check whether that meaning fits the rest of the passage.
5. State the effect in plain language: what becomes clearer, stronger, more vivid, or more emotional?

Tips and shortcuts

- Translate the figurative phrase into a plain sentence before looking at the choices.
- Do not choose an answer just because it names the device correctly.
- Avoid symbolic interpretations that the passage gives no evidence for.

Worked examples

Example 1

By noon, the unanswered emails had become a wall between Priya and the work she actually needed to finish.

1. What does the metaphor suggest?

- A. Priya works beside a physical wall.
- B. The emails have become an obstacle that blocks her attention.
- C. Priya plans to leave the office.
- D. The emails were printed and stacked.

Answer: B

A wall blocks movement. The metaphor transfers that idea to the emails, showing that they are preventing progress.

Example 2

The first notes of the old piano stumbled into the room.

2. What is the effect of this phrase?

- A. It makes the notes seem uncertain and imperfect.
- B. It proves the piano moved across the floor.
- C. It shows that the room is dangerous.
- D. It explains how the piano was built.

Answer: A

Stumbled gives the sound a hesitant, imperfect quality, which helps the reader imagine the uneven beginning.

Common traps

- A literal reading of a nonliteral phrase.
- Naming simile/metaphor/personification without explaining meaning.
- A vague answer such as "it makes it interesting."
- An elaborate symbolic meaning unsupported by the passage.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, point to the exact word, phrase, or surrounding detail that proves your interpretation. If you cannot point to evidence, recheck the choice.

Quick check

1. Translate "the deadline was breathing down his neck" into plain language.
2. What quality is transferred in "the city woke slowly"?
3. Why is "it is a metaphor" often an incomplete answer?

Quick check guidance

Say your answer in plain language and explain which exact wording in the sentence or passage supports it. The goal is evidence-based interpretation, not memorizing labels.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: You read the expression literally.

Try: Ask what comparison or image the words create and what idea that image communicates.

2

If: You correctly name the device but miss its meaning.

Try: The exam usually cares more about what the figurative language shows or emphasizes than the label itself.

3

If: You overstate the effect of one image.

Try: Connect the image to nearby evidence. Do not invent an emotion or theme that the passage does not support.

30-second reset

Before the next figurative language question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.